Suddenly, the spel was broken. The second stage went out of control. The flight was terminated after 317 seconds and the vehicle's remains, including my favourite fourth stage with the payload splashed into the sea, 560 km off Sriharikota.

The incident caused us profound disappointment. I felt a strange mix of anger and frustration. Suddenly, I felt my legs become so stiff that they ached. The problem was not with my body; something was happening in my mind.

The premature death of my hovercraft Nandi, the abandoning of the RATO, the abortion of the SLV-Diamont fourth stage—al came alive in a flash, like a long-buried Phoenix rising from its ashes. Over the years, I had somehow learned to absorb these aborted endeavours, had come to terms with them and pursued fresh dreams. That day, I re-lived each of those setbacks in my deep despondency.

"What do you suppose could be the cause of it?" somebody asked me in the Block House. I tried to find an answer, but I was too tired to try and think it out, and gave up the effort as futile. The launch was conducted in the early morning, preceded by a ful night's count-down. Moreover, I